SpeechGeek



Season Ten: Winter 2013

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Looking back, 2012 has been an action-packed year. *The Avengers* and *The Dark Knight* muscled their way into theaters and rescued lagging box office sales. Strength and agility also helped U.S. Olympians like Gabby Douglas bring home the gold. And chances are—if you're reading this—the Mayan calendar is being filed away with Y2K in the "Unnecessary End-of-the-Year Worries" box.

While everyone is trying to remember to write the right year, you've got plenty of other things keeping you busy. We're in the full swing of tournament season with district, state, and even national tournaments on the horizon. Your brain is chock full of memorized pieces, tournament planning to-do lists, and polishing pieces after reading ballots. The last thing you need to remember is to go out searching for new literature. That's why we went ahead and published five new pieces in addition to this letter. What a bargain!

Here's hoping that 2013 brings you good fortune, great ballots, and unforgettable performances!

Corey Alderdice
Publisher



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Content

by Wes Tantz

(*While smoking cigarette, Marion should be making subtle touches to her stomach because she is with child—but it shouldn't be obvious.)*

MARION. (*reading from book*) "Poets are always taking the weather so seriously. They are always sticking their emotions in things that have no feelings."

When I first started writing, I used to hail these gaudy beings as proof for why I was the way I was or why I did the things I did. After months of reading, re-reading, and a descent into nihilism, I just realized I was a woman who was too busy rotating on my axis to focus on the planets and shooting stars around me.

(*reading from book)* "All cowardice comes from not loving or not loving well."

Then again, maybe that's what it is. All of these people are too much on their axis, too. Or too busy sucking the life out of anything that remained nameless. You know, I never understood why love was such a holy topic. It's not all that, let me tell you. Let me tell you a story.

I knew a girl once who fell so in love with a boy. She fell and fell and fell and fell so far past the Earth that she spiraled out into the universe. She was carried by all these feelings that seemed warm and comforting, but once thrown into space, they were nothing. She floated with the dust and fell and fell and came to a black hole. There, she was sucked inside, and what did she find? Well, a party! There was booze, there was coke, there were people, and she danced until the stars shook and fell to her feet. There was John Lennon, Albert Einstein, and Ernest Hemingway. And you'll never believe who was hosting the party. Jesus H. Christ himself! Dressed in a pink suit, all Gatsby-like. So cool and so clique, waiting on his Daisy to float on by…(*laughs*). Hmm. You know that's why people never return from black holes. It's one endless party. I mean who'd want to? She sent me a postcard once. It was real nice. Jesus is a handsome looking fellow let me tell you. (*She laughs and continues to smoke.*)

Dividing by Zero

by Sarah Carpenter

SCENE 1

KATE. (*Kate is center stage, addressing audience. Until she speaks directly to Jeff, they are not in the same scene together.*) To answer your question, no. No, there was never a time when I didn't want to be a mother.

JEFF. (*enters*) Katie? You home?

KATE. I'm sorry. That sounded convoluted. What I meant to say was that I've always wanted to be a mother. I feel like, deep down, I was born to be a mother.

JEFF. (*putting down bags and books*) Katie? Katie-kat? Where are ya, girl?

KATE. It's funny. You know how most little girls carry around baby dolls? Me? I had my own nursery. I knew which blankie went with each baby. I made up feeding and changing charts. My babies didn't cry. Instead, they had colic. I took a yellow highlighter to one doll and began treating her for jaundice. I mean, seriously? What six-year-old diagnoses their baby doll with *jaundice?*

JEFF. (*opens fridge*) Well whadd've we got here? (*He calls out in a half-whisper half-talk so that—even if she's in the house—she can't hear him.*) Kate, I'm going to polish off the orange juice straight out of the carton. If that's cool with you, just say something.

KATE. So on our third date, when Jeff confessed that he would steal his sister's dolls and hide them under his shirt so he could pretend to be pregnant, I wasn't weirded out. Actually, I thought it was serendipity. Here's a cute, funny, and nice guy who wants kids as much as I do. It's perfect. (*moment*) After everything we went through, it should have been the perfect day. (*to Jeff*) It's positive.

JEFF. Are you positive?

KATE. (*to Jeff*) I'm positive.

JEFF. Katie-kat this is the best news in the world! Augh! I love ya!

SCENE 2

KATE. (*to audience*) Let me back things up.

JEFF. What does it say?

KATE. (*to Jeff*) It hasn't been two minutes yet.

JEFF. You're not doing it right.

KATE. Not doing it right? I'm peeing on a stick, Jeff, not launching a space shuttle.

JEFF. You know they probably only have one little red start button to push. I bet those control panels are just for show.

KATE. Yes, Jeff, I'm sure NASA likes to employ prop technicians to make fake control panels for their space missions.

JEFF. And the guys sitting at home with the big computer screens. Those are all fake, too. You know they're just sitting around watching re-runs of *Friends* on our taxpayer dollars.

KATE. That is the most realistic conspiracy theory ever. You should contact *The Onion.* I'm sure they'd love to publish your groundbreaking exposé.

JEFF. Yeah, yeah, yeah. It's been two minutes. Flip it over.

KATE. (*Kate takes a deep breath, looks at Jeff, then turns it over with an exhale.*) Nope.

JEFF. Seriously?

KATE. (*irritated*) What? Do you think I would joke about this?

JEFF. I didn't say that.

KATE. You said "seriously" like I wasn't being serious or something. So, yeah, I stand by my question.

JEFF. Wow. Well, I'm sorry. I'm a little disappointed by the whole thing.

KATE. I am, too. You're not the only one feeling this way.

JEFF. I thought we would catch a break this time.

KATE. After three years of trying to get pregnant, one would think.

JEFF. Do you think it's time we called in the experts?

KATE. Who? NASA?

JEFF. (*laughs)* No. I don't want a cardboard prop baby. I want a real baby. One that's all pudgy and cute and cries and poops.

KATE. So do I. You're right. I should probably call my doctor.

JEFF. Say that again.

KATE. (*confused)* I should call my doctor?

JEFF. Before that.

KATE. (*sighs)* You're right.

JEFF. It's just so rare to hear you say those words.

SCENE 3

DOCTOR. Hello, Kate, how are you doing this afternoon?

KATE. Oh, you know. Just lounging in my backless hospital gown on a paper covered exam table…so I'm pretty much feeling like Angelina Jolie. Except, minus the babies, of course.

DOCTOR. Yes…. About that. I take it you've been actively trying to conceive?

KATE. If sheer desire and willpower were enough, we would have created one with our minds by now.

DOCTOR. Have you read the pamph…

KATE. I've read every pamphlet and every website. I don't smoke. I cut out caffeine. I eat a balanced diet. Drink plenty of water. I exercise.

DOCTOR. (*gets cut off*) And charting…

KATE. I've charted my monthly cycles. I've charted my ovulation. I've charted my body temperature.

DOCTOR. And your husband…

KATE. Has already seen his doctor. This is the last stop.

DOCTOR. Well. We'll run some tests and see what we can find out. In the meantime, try not to worry so much.

SCENE 4

KATE. (*to audience*) We weren't going to give up without a fight. When the doctor said our best chance was to go through fertility treatments, we did it. It cost thousands of dollars…money we didn't really have. But eventually, it worked. (*to Jeff*) It's positive.

JEFF. Are you positive?

KATE. (*to Jeff*) I'm positive.

JEFF. Katie-kat this is the best news in the world! Augh! I love ya!

KATE. (*to audience*) For a while, things were great. We were in this sparkly fog. We'd pick out paint samples, talk about names, and coo whenever we walked through the baby aisle.

JEFF. Look at these baby socks. They're teeny! I could just eat them up like M&M's.

KATE. The first ten weeks were great. It wasn't until I went in for a check-up that I got the news.

DOCTOR. Hello, Kate. How are you feeling this morning?

KATE. Nauseous, but I'm okay with that. It means I'm pregnant after all!

DOCTOR. It does. I just received a copy of your ultrasound, and there are a few things that we need to discuss.

KATE. Is everything okay?

DOCTOR. The ultrasound indicated that you have significant thinning in the uterine walls. This is probably why it was so difficult for you to conceive on your own.

KATE. What does that mean, doctor?

DOCTOR. The amount of thinning we've detected this early puts you in the severely high-risk category. Had this been caught earlier, we could have started you on some steroid treatments that would have better built up the muscle tissue.

KATE. But what about right now?

DOCTOR. As the pregnancy continues, you stand an increasing risk of experiencing a rupture, which puts you and the baby in danger. There are women who carry their pregnancies to term without an incident. But for your health as well as the baby's—you have to be informed. You're a ticking time bomb, Kate. The other option…should you want to receive steroid treatments and try to conceive again later…

KATE. Are you suggesting…?

DOCTOR. I'm only telling you what your options are. I can only give you information. You have to make the best decision for yourself and your family.

KATE. (*to audience*) Jeff was eerily silent when I told him about the doctor's appointment. I told him everything, every detail. He wouldn't say anything for the longest time. He just stared at the ground and nodded at the appropriate intervals. Finally, he looked up and said.

JEFF. So, what you're saying is that you just need to be on bed rest 'til the baby gets here, right?

KATE. Jeff, it's more complicated than that. I don't think you understand…

JEFF. No, I understand. The pregnancy is risky.

KATE. It's more than risky, Jeff. It's dangerous. Practically life-threatening right now.

JEFF. He didn't use that phrase "life-threatening" did he?

KATE. "Ticking time bomb" is pretty close.

JEFF. Bombs don't always explode.

KATE. You're just going to pretend that everything is fine?

JEFF. You're just going to throw in the towel at the first set back?

KATE. Excuse me?

JEFF. You're just scared and looking for a way out.

KATE. Of course I'm scared. I'm terrified, and with sound, medical reasons to boot. I don't get how you can remain "full steam ahead" when the doctor is making it very clear that this is dangerous.

JEFF. Your doctor is a quack.

KATE. My doctor is a leader in his field. He's the best in the state.

JEFF. What you want to do is unspeakable.

KATE. What? Save my life? Prevent horrible pain for this little one and myself? Plan to recover and get better so we can try again?

JEFF. We've depleted our savings. This is it.

KATE. Then we can adopt.

JEFF. I don't want to adopt.

KATE. What?

JEFF. That's not an option.

KATE. Why is that not an option? You've always wanted kids.

JEFF. I've wanted kids *of my own*. Adopting someone else's kid isn't the same.

KATE. (*stunned*) Wow… wow.

JEFF. Quit trying to make me the bad guy here. I have done nothing but support you.

KATE. Apparently you've done nothing but support your own desire to continue your genetic line.

JEFF. I cannot let you end this pregnancy.

KATE. Jeff! This pregnancy could kill me. What part of that do you not understand? (*Jeff doesn't flinch.*) Wait. (*realization*) It isn't that you don't think I could die…it's that you wouldn't be devastated if I did, isn't it?

JEFF. I never said that.

KATE. Say it, then.

JEFF. What?

KATE. Say, "I would be devastated if you died in childbirth."

JEFF. Katie, you're sick.

KATE. Say it.

JEFF. I'm not going to play your little game.

KATE. Say it.

JEFF. Stop screaming. It's not good for… (*stops*)

KATE. For what?

JEFF. For the baby. My baby.

KATE. So that's it? I'm just here to carry your child? (*Jeff is silent.*) Then what? If something horrible happens then you just start fresh with a new wife? Someone who can get pregnant and fill your entire home with babies? Some picture perfect world where you get to play happy home-making daddy and there aren't any problems at all? That's what you want?

JEFF. What I want is for you to shut up and sit down before you send yourself into labor. That's what I want.

KATE. What did you just say to…

JEFF. (*interrupts*) Let me make myself clear for the last time. What you're talking about is unthinkable. If you go through with it, I'm through with you. Period. (*exits)*

KATE. (*center stage and alone with the audience*) Sorry. I'm sorry. I'm sure you're used to it. Women crying while signing divorce papers. (*gets emotional*) People talk about blessings in disguise. They talk about how something horrible happens, but then you look back on it and see that deep down it was a good thing. Sometimes it's the opposite. Sometimes something beautiful and wonderful happens and it's just covering up something horrible and ugly and tragic. People don't like to talk about those things. How the thing you want most in the world can tear everything else apart. We don't like to be reminded how quickly things can be ruined. How something can start positive…

JEFF. (*voice from behind, echoing the initial excitement in the beginning*) Positive!

KATE. Could turn out so negative. Thanks for listening.